Polymarket copy-trading: what actually works in 2026

The Polymarket copy-trading ecosystem has exploded since late 2025, but it remains a minefield of broken APIs, inflated GitHub repos, and outright scams. The most reliable path for non-coders is a Telegram bot like PolyCop (0.5% fee, non-custodial) or Stand.trade (web-based, endorsed by Polymarket itself). For developers, the only battle-tested architecture is a two-layer system: monitor trades via the Data API or WebSocket, then execute through the CLOB API using Polymarket's official `py-clob-client` (Python) or `clob-client` (TypeScript). PyPI Both official libraries are actively maintained as of March 2026, Polymarket GitHub but both are plagued with authentication issues that have frustrated developers for months. There is no testnet — you test with real money or not at all. AgentBets

Telegram bots have become the dominant no-code solution

The fastest way to start copy-trading without writing code is through Telegram bots. Three have emerged as credible options, each independently verified by at least one third-party review:

PolyCop (@PolyCop_BOT) charges **0.5% per trade** — the lowest fee in the category — and operates non-custodially, meaning your private keys stay in your Telegram session and are exportable. PolyCop Medium It was independently tested by BullRank with $60 USDC across 25 trades over 48 hours, verifying actual fee receipts. Bullrank Its unique feature is limit order copying with a price offset, letting you enter at better prices than the trader you're mirroring (e.g., -3% from their fill). defipill The downside: no manual trading, no wallet discovery tools, and a $50 minimum balance. defipill

PolyGun (@PolyGunSniperBot) is a better all-in-one option at **1% per trade**, sponsoring gas fees Medium so you don't need MATIC. Medium It supports copy trading plus manual trading, limit orders, AI predictions, and auto-bridging from Polygon, Solana, Ethereum, and BNB. Medium Multiple review sites cover it positively, though many Medium reviews contain affiliate links and should be read skeptically.

Polycule (@polycule_trade_bot) was one of the first and most popular bots but suffered a **$230,000 hack in January 2026** due to its custodial architecture. Medium Attackers exploited SSRF vulnerabilities and forged copy-trading events. Bullrank It's back online post-patch, but the fundamental risk of a custodial design — the server holds your keys — remains. Non-custodial alternatives are strictly safer. Bullrank

Beyond Telegram, **Stand.trade** is the most credible web-based platform, Polymarket endorsed directly by Polymarket's newsletter and founder-interviewed by their official podcast. Polymarket It aggregates Polymarket and Kalshi markets, offers whale watching with PnL-based filtering, and supports copy trading with auto-execute or manual confirmation. Polymark **FrenFlow** charges only performance fees on profits (no subscription), has sub-second processing, and uses

multiple blockchain providers for redundancy. **Ratio** offers native iOS and Android apps with paper trading mode and bot-detection scoring. Medium

GitHub is polluted with scam repos, but a few are genuine

The Polymarket copy-trading space on GitHub is **heavily contaminated with SEO-spam repositories** — keyword-stuffed descriptions, purchased star counts, and ZIP-file downloads that may contain malware. In December 2025, researchers found private-key-stealing code in a popular open-source copy-trading repo, and in January 2026, a "ClawdBot" malware appeared via a typo-squatted package. Medium Audit every line of code before running anything.

Official Polymarket repositories (github.com/Polymarket) are the only safe starting point:

- **py-clob-client** — Python, ~940 stars, updated Feb 22, 2026 (v0.34.6). The foundational Python library for all CLOB operations. GitHub Has 84 open issues, mostly authentication problems, but is actively releasing. GitHub
- **clob-client** — TypeScript, ~485 stars, updated Mar 24, 2026. GitHub Same functionality for Node.js. Updated literally yesterday. GitHub Supports both ethers v5 and viem. GitHub
- **real-time-data-client** — TypeScript, ~193 stars, updated Mar 5, 2026. GitHubWebSocket client for real-time market data streaming. GitHub Essential for any monitoring system.
- **agents** — Python, ~1,700 stars. Official AI trading agent framework GitHub using LangChain. GitHub Only supports market orders (no limit orders yet), GitHub and has 101 unmerged PRs.
- **polymarket-cli** — Rust, ~1,837 stars. GitHub CLI trading tool, popular with power users.

Among community repos, only a handful survive scrutiny. **direkturcrypto/polymarket-terminal** (JavaScript, 4 stars, 9 forks) is a well-engineered multi-function terminal with a copy-trade bot using WebSocket monitoring, FAK market buys, GTC fallback, per-market queuing to prevent duplicate buys, and a dry-run simulation mode. GitHub Low star count actually suggests legitimacy — it hasn't been botted. **echandsome/Polymarket-betting-bot** (TypeScript, 6 stars, 23 commits) shows real development effort with proper project structure including controllers, services, routes, and MongoDB models. GitHub **warproxxx/poly-maker** (Python, 633 stars, 22 commits) isn't a copy-trader but is the highest-quality community trading bot overall — a market maker with Google Sheets configuration GitHub whose author also maintains `poly_data`, a comprehensive Polymarket data pipeline GitHub useful for identifying wallets worth copying.

The most-starred copy-trading repo — **0xmike-poly/polymarket-copy-trading-bot** (698 stars, 614 forks) — has only **one commit**, a classic indicator of purchased stars. The README is technically sound and the code structure looks legitimate, but approach it with extreme caution. The QuickNode copy-trading bot guide (TypeScript) is the most trustworthy tutorial-style implementation, published by a major infrastructure provider with verifiable code. QuickNode

The two-layer CLOB architecture is the only proven approach

Every working copy-trading system uses the same fundamental design: a **monitoring layer** to detect trades and an **execution layer** to replicate them through the CLOB API. (QuickNode)

For monitoring, developers choose between three methods ranked by speed. **WebSocket subscriptions** (`wss://ws-subscriptions-clob.polymarket.com/ws/market`) deliver real-time updates fastest (AgentBets) but require knowing which markets to subscribe to in advance. **Data API polling** (`data-api.polymarket.com/trades` filtered by wallet address) is simplest to implement (QuickNode) at 2–5 second intervals and is what most production bots use. (GitHub) (QuickNode) **On-chain Polygon monitoring** watches blockchain events directly from target wallets (GitHub) and offers the fastest detection for large trades but is significantly harder to implement and requires a reliable Polygon RPC node. (GitHub)

For execution, the CLOB API is the only option — there's no alternative path to place orders. The community strongly recommends **FOK (Fill or Kill) orders** for copy trading to avoid partial fills and stale orders. Advanced bots use a three-phase strategy: initial order attempt, progressive price adjustments if unfilled, then cancellation after a timeout. (GitHub +2)

Speed is everything. (Medium)Polymarket's own newsletter documented the "Copytrade Wars" — prices adjust within **1–3 seconds** of a whale trade. Bots executing under 2 seconds capture most of the edge; at 10 seconds, the opportunity is gone. (Medium) Top traders now run secondary and tertiary wallets to evade copiers, and some execute decoy trades to punish followers. (Polymarket) Only **0.51% of all Polymarket wallets** have ever profited more than $1,000, (Medium) a sobering statistic for anyone expecting copy trading to be a money printer. (Medium)

The API will fight you at every step

The Polymarket API ecosystem has specific, well-documented failure modes that explain why AI-generated code consistently breaks. These are the real issues developers hit, drawn from GitHub issue threads and firsthand developer accounts:

401 Unauthorized is the #1 problem. Dozens of GitHub issues report this across both Python and TypeScript clients. (GitHub) The root causes are subtle: confusion between signature types (type 0 for EOA/MetaMask wallets, type 1 for Magic/email wallets), not setting the `funder` address correctly for proxy wallets, (GitHub) or manually passing credentials instead of using `create_or_derive_api_creds()`. (GitHub) (GitHub) One developer reported that `cancel_all()` works with the same client instance where `post_order()` returns 401 (GitHub) — a maddening inconsistency. (GitHub) As of February 2026, users on the latest py-clob-client v0.34.6 still report this issue unresolved. (GitHub)

"Not enough balance/allowance" errors are the second most common trap. (GitHub) EOA users must **set ERC-20 token allowances** for the exchange contracts before their first trade (GitHub) (PyPI) — a one-time setup step that no tutorial adequately emphasizes. (GitHub) Even after setup,

sell orders frequently fail: one user reported buying 5 shares successfully but only being able to sell 4.5, with the remaining 0.5 falling below the minimum order size (GitHub) — yet selling works fine through the Polymarket website. (GitHub)

WebSocket connections silently freeze. A detailed March 2026 bug report documents the CLOB WebSocket accepting connections, responding to PINGs, but delivering zero market data for hours. The workaround is a data inactivity watchdog that force-reconnects after 120 seconds of silence, combined with REST midpoint spot-checks. (GitHub)

Polymarket ships breaking changes without warning. On February 18, 2026, they removed the ~500ms artificial delay on crypto market taker orders with no announcement. (GitHub) (DEV Community) One developer wrote: "Half the bots on the platform broke overnight." (DEV Community) In January 2026, dynamic taker fees appeared on crypto markets (up to ~1.56% at 50% probability), and orders on fee-enabled markets now **must** include `feeRateBps` in the signed payload or get silently rejected. (DEV Community) There is **no testnet or sandbox environment** — all development happens against production with real money. (AgentBets)

Pin your dependencies. The Python client specifically requires `web3==6.14.0` to avoid compatibility issues. (QuantVPS) (QuantVPS) The TypeScript client expects ethers v5, not v6 — the QuickNode guide explicitly warns about this. (QuickNode) Version mismatches cause cryptic signing failures that look like authentication errors.

TypeScript wins for copy trading, Python for prototyping

Both languages have official, maintained CLOB clients, (Polymarket) but they serve different purposes in practice.

TypeScript (`@polymarket/clob-client`) is what most production copy-trading bots actually run. It was updated March 24, 2026 (GitHub) — one day before this report. The official `real-time-data-client` WebSocket library is TypeScript-only, giving JS developers native access to the fastest monitoring method. The QuickNode copy-trading tutorial is TypeScript. Most Telegram bots (PolyGun, PolyCop) run on Node.js. TypeScript's async patterns handle the concurrent monitoring and execution loops more naturally than Python's threading.

Python (`py-clob-client`, v0.34.6) (PyPI) has the larger community and more tutorials, making it better for learning and prototyping. The official AI agent framework is Python. (GitHub) `warproxxx/poly-maker` — the best-documented real-world trading bot — is Python. (GitHub) But Python has a critical performance limitation: **order signing takes approximately one second per signature**, which is far too slow when arbitrage opportunities vanish in seconds. (QuantVPS) Python also has the most open issues (84 vs 36 for TypeScript) and stricter version-pinning requirements.

Rust is what serious HFT operators use. The community `polyfill-rs` library claims zero-allocation hot paths with SIMD JSON parsing and 21% faster performance than the official

client. GitHub DEV Community If your cancel loop takes more than 200ms, you'll get adversely selected in fast markets. DEV Community Rust is overkill for copy trading but worth noting for context.

For someone who has struggled with AI-generated Python code, **TypeScript is the pragmatic choice for copy trading.** The ecosystem is better maintained, the monitoring libraries are native, and the QuickNode guide provides a complete, verifiable reference implementation from a reputable source.

Conclusion

The Polymarket copy-trading landscape in March 2026 is simultaneously more accessible and more treacherous than it was a year ago. Non-coders should start with **PolyCop** (Telegram, 0.5% fee, non-custodial) or **Stand.trade** (web, Polymarket-endorsed) rather than fighting the API directly. Developers who want full control should build on **TypeScript with the official clob-client and real-time-data-client**, using the QuickNode guide as a reference implementation — not random GitHub repos, which are overwhelmingly spam or malware. The 401 authentication error is not your fault; it's a systemic issue that even experienced developers struggle with, GitHub GitHub rooted in subtle signature-type mismatches that the documentation inadequately explains. GitHub Start with a dedicated EOA wallet (not a Magic/email wallet), use `create_or_derive_api_creds()`, QuantVPS pin all dependency versions, and test with $1 trades before scaling. QuickNode Most importantly, recognize that the profitable copy-trading window is shrinking: top traders actively evade copiers, Bullrank Polymarket prices adjust in seconds, Medium and the platform ships breaking changes without notice. Polymarket